

being overconfident about the seat. "They made the mistake of thinking that this was their stronghold, similar to what Rae Bareilly and Amethi have been for Indiraji, Soniaji or Rahulji," he said. This unsolicited election analysis could not have gone down too well with Mulayam's son Akhilesh who is being projected as SP's answer to Rahul Gandhi.

There have been whispers of a turf war between Amar Singh and the Yadav family, with the suave young scion ganging up with his uncle Ram Gopal Yadav against his father's best friend and counsellor. Six months ago, when Singh was in Singapore for his kidney transplant, it was the young Akhilesh who replaced him in Delhi, speaking to the TV cameras about the party's point of view during the Parliament session. Singh also said that he was hurt by the fact that Mulayam had visited him only once in Singapore. And for some time, he was smarting at being solely blamed for the tie-up with Kalyan Singh that cost the party Muslim votes in the last Lok Sabha elections.

Interestingly Singh claims that this is his fourth resignation from the party posts of general secretary, spokesman and member of parliamentary board. "I had resigned on three occasions in the past but on each occasion Netaji had rejected my request. I hold him in high esteem," he says. For his part, Mulayam says that he has only heard about the resignations from the media. "This is an internal party matter. He has not resigned from the party." This limited resignation has led to speculation in the SP that Singh merely wants to renegotiate his relationship with Mulayam and is not looking to join any other party. "Family and my health come first for me. Doctors have advised me rest," says Singh.

There is little doubt that the ever-smiling Singh is hurt. Last month, he took a digital page from his friend Amitabh's book and began a blog where he talks about the Firozabad defeat. "One has to prove oneself time

and again. Some time you have to fight outsiders and sometime you have to deal with your own family members," he writes. Surprisingly, both Sonia and Rahul are praised consistently in his blog, as is his Netaji. Yet the feeling of disillusion persists. He ends the year on a note of introspection: "I have learnt to take personal criticism in my stride and, for the first time in my political career, I am giving more preference to my family and, in the bargain, I have chosen to ignore council elections in Uttar Pradesh. No one is indispensable. I am desperate to create my po-

with much disdain by the rustic Samajwadis are being touted in his blog as major achievements. Perhaps he has been reading the writing on the walls in the badlands of western Uttar Pradesh.

Still, he could well be persuaded to rethink his resignation. As a former colleague Beni Prasad Verma says, "The world knows that Mulayam Singh and Amar Singh cannot live without each other. It's a move to silence the critics within the Yadav family and the party."

Also remember: there are no full stops in the Amar story, there are only

There is talk of a **TURF WAR** between Amar Singh and the Yadav family with the heir-apparent taking on his father's best friend.

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MULAYAM SINGH WITH SON AKHILESH (RIGHT) AND DAUGHTER-IN-LAW DIMPLE

litical dispensability in order to avoid unnecessary tension which is detrimental to my health... I want to reinvent myself as a family-oriented person." Of course, being Amar Singh, the introspection is right there, in full public glare.

The process of reinvention has already begun. The smoothest political networker today sees himself as a "global citizen". His social conquests such as dining with the Clintons and wining with the Blairs that were met

pauses. The latest one may be necessitated by health and climate change in the political planet. He is at his manoeuvring best when power is a game for the foxiest to win, when the imminence of defeat is an opportunity for victory and when he is the axis of the political whirl. Today, to his horror, there is an unbearable sense of stability in the political bazaar, making him almost redundant. So it perhaps suits him to retreat for a while. Wait for the next big political muddle and Amar Singh may burst out of your nearest TV screen.

with Farzand Ahmed and Subhash Mishra